herself when she asked them why they still needed weapons when their mission of killing Rajiv Gandhi had already been achieved. None of the assassins were expecting such a question from her—she almost sounded like a cop. Nero lost his cool. He advised Mridula to keep her mouth shut, or she knew what the consequence would be—death. All of them left at 10.30 p.m. Ranganath, Mridula, Sivarasan, Suresh Master, Shubha, Nero, Driver Anna and Amman left in the Maruti Gypsy. Nine people fitting into one Gypsy was difficult and Mridula said she had put her foot down by refusing to go with them. But Suresh Master and Nero forced her into the vehicle. Mridula said she was praying for an end to her situation all through the journey.[4]

On the morning of 18 August, Mridula came across sketches of KRS Dam and Vidhan Soudha, the state legislature building of Karnataka. Were they planning to bomb those places? She could not help asking them about it. Shubha tried to give her an answer but Mridula was not convinced. At that point, Shubha came down hard on her—either Mridula stopped asking questions, or she faced the consequences. But Mridula didn't stop there. She asked Shubha what she meant by 'consequences', as she had been hearing it from their mouths time and again. Shubha didn't react. She just smiled and left the room. Suddenly a newspaper lying around caught Mridula's attention. It carried the news of twelve LTTE cadres taking cyanide capsules in Muthati during a police raid. That day, Mridula and Ranganath had a series of arguments. She insisted that they leave the house as the situation was becoming dangerous. The police might be coming to their doorstep at any moment. But none of the fugitives liked the idea of Ranganath leaving. It was at that point that Mridula had an asthma attack. She did not fake it. But instead of going to the doctor, she decided to go back to her house in Putanahally.

A neighbour from Putanahally had helped them get a Matador van to carry their stuff. They had gone straight to Mridula's brother's house in the Shanthi Oliver Church campus. On the way, Ranganath had got off to make a phone call and told Mridula to continue on her journey—he would meet her later. Around 4.30 p.m. the next day, Mridula was taking a few saris to a